EL SALVADOR (14 February)

Harvesting of the 2002/03 second season coarse grain crops has been completed and the aggregate maize output for the year (both crops) is provisionally estimated at a well above-average 637 000 tonnes. Production of sorghum is about 139 000 tonnes, similar to last year but below the past five-year average of 168 000 tonnes. Production of beans, an important staple, is estimated at 82 000 tonnes, as compared to last year's well above-average volume of 84 000 tonnes. The coffee crisis is still affecting the sector and is likely to continue in the months ahead. Cases of severe malnutrition among children are reported, particularly in the provinces of Ahuachapan and Sonsonate in the west. Food assistance from the international community is being provided to some 2 200 families. The possibility of food assistance in other coffee producing areas is also being considered.

Wheat imports in marketing year 2002/03 (August/July) are expected to be about 195 000 tonnes, similar to the volume imported in the previous year. Maize imports are forecast at 335 000 tonnes, considerably above the volume of imports in 2001/02.

